

Surveillance-Focused Privacy Game: Design Components

This document outlines a comprehensive set of design components for a children's privacy education game, derived from comparative analysis of existing privacy and internet safety games. The focus is explicitly on surveillance, data collection, inference, and algorithmic profiling rather than surface-level safety tips.

1. Access & Trust Requirements

- No account creation, login, or third-party platform dependency
- Fully web-based with instant access and no download required
- No tracking, cookies, or analytics beyond essential session storage
- In-game transparency screen explaining exactly what data is and is not collected
- Optional toggle that simulates tracking on/off to demonstrate consequences of surveillance

2. Core Gameplay Structure

- Action-driven gameplay that prioritizes exploration and interaction over quizzes
- Educational content embedded into mechanics rather than pop-up questions
- Persistent consequences for player decisions across the game world
- Minimal interruptions to gameplay flow to avoid an assignment-like feel

3. Surveillance as a Core Game Mechanic

- Hidden data collection layer that tracks player behavior such as choices, timing, movement, and risk tolerance
- Inference system that builds a behavioral profile of the player over time
- Dynamic changes to NPC behavior, rewards, and difficulty based on inferred traits
- Periodic reveal moments where players see the profile constructed about them

4. Player Agency and Resistance

- Meaningful privacy settings that directly impact gameplay outcomes
- Options to opt out, obfuscate data, feed false information, or reset identity

- Clear tradeoffs between convenience, personalization, rewards, and autonomy
- Mechanics that demonstrate both the power and limitations of resisting surveillance

5. RealWorld Surveillance Scenarios

- Behavioral advertising that follows the player across different game areas
- Location and pattern inference based on repeated in-game actions
- Shadow profiling that persists even when players attempt to opt out
- Social graph inference using NPC relationships and proximity
- Algorithmic nudging that subtly shapes player decisions over time

6. Instruction Without Lecturing

- Short, contextual explanations delivered after key events
- Visual breakdowns showing how data moved through the system
- NPC dialogue that reflects emotional and social consequences of surveillance
- No long text blocks or mandatory reading sections

7. Progression and Motivation Systems

- Multi-zone or multi-phase structure with escalating complexity
- Reward systems based on narrative outcomes rather than points alone
- Multiple endings determined by privacy behavior and resistance strategies
- Replayability driven by discovering alternative outcomes and system behaviors

8. Visualizing the Invisible

- Data flows represented visually as particles, streams, or energy
- Evolving profile dashboards that show inferred traits and predictions
- Surveillance entities that grow stronger as more data is collected
- Heat maps and overlays that reveal patterns after gameplay segments

9. Ethical Consistency

- The game itself practices the privacy principles it teaches
- No deceptive data collection or hidden tracking of players
- Clear alignment between narrative, mechanics, and ethical stance
- Opportunities for players to inspect and critique the system itself

Design Positioning Statement

This game teaches online privacy through simulated surveillance systems that actively profile the player, revealing how modern data collection, inference, and personalization operate beneath the surface of everyday digital interactions. Rather than relying on quizzes or simple warnings, the game builds understanding through experiential learning and long-term consequences.